soon renamed the Pacific Squadron, cruising along the western coasts of North and South America. A year later, the USS *Congress* became the first American naval vessel to enter Chinese waters, followed only sporadically afterward for over a decade, until the formation in 1835 of the East India Squadron, based in Asia proper, which was later renamed the Asiatic Squadron.[12] These two squadrons, of varying sizes and effectiveness, but never more than a handful of ships, patrolled the Indo-Pacific region for the rest of the century, occasionally intervening on behalf of scattered merchants and missionaries.

If there was an overall American approach to the Pacific world in the first century of its engagement, it might be conceived of as consisting of different types of activity in three "zones." These zones were never explicitly articulated as such, nor were they consciously thought of as distinct spaces, but the differing ways Americans approached the Pacific during the nineteenth century reveal an understanding of the scope and limits of US power in the Pacific until the dawn of the twentieth century.

First, along the western coast of the American continent, a "zone of control" was eventually established, patrolled by the US Navy. This zone operated as part of the broader imperial competition between the United States, Great Britain, Spain, Mexico, and Russia over the new territories of western North America. In particular, this zone saw American moves to counter British attempts to carve out a permanent presence deep into what would become the Oregon Territory, protected by the Royal Navy.[13] The Treaty of Oregon, signed on June 15, 1846, set the forty-ninth parallel as the border between British Canada and the United States, thereby incorporating the future states of Washington and Oregon into American territory and blocking British expansion southward. At the same time, the wresting of California from Mexico during the Mexican-American War of 1846–48 ensured the control of some of the most fertile land on the entire continent and gave the United States a coastline reaching from the northern Pacific down to temperate waters off the Baja California peninsula. Within this zone of control, the United States exercised complete maritime and